

April 2026

PLANNED PARENTHOOD UX AUDIT

Website Usability Analysis

Site URL: www.plannedparenthood.org

AUDITED BY: Averie Dow (UX2 Student)

University of Colorado Boulder

Prof. Tyler Benari



ABOUT THE AUDITOR

Averie Dow

Education: Senior studying Information Science, Creative Technology & Design, and User Experience at **CU Boulder**.

Mission: Designer dedicated to accessibility and authenticity.

Background: accessibility auditing and higher-ed design.

Portfolio: averiedow.com



PART ONE

Introduction to Planned Parenthood Audit

AUDIT OBJECTIVE

Purpose

Evaluate how Planned Parenthood health information and services are explained so they are:

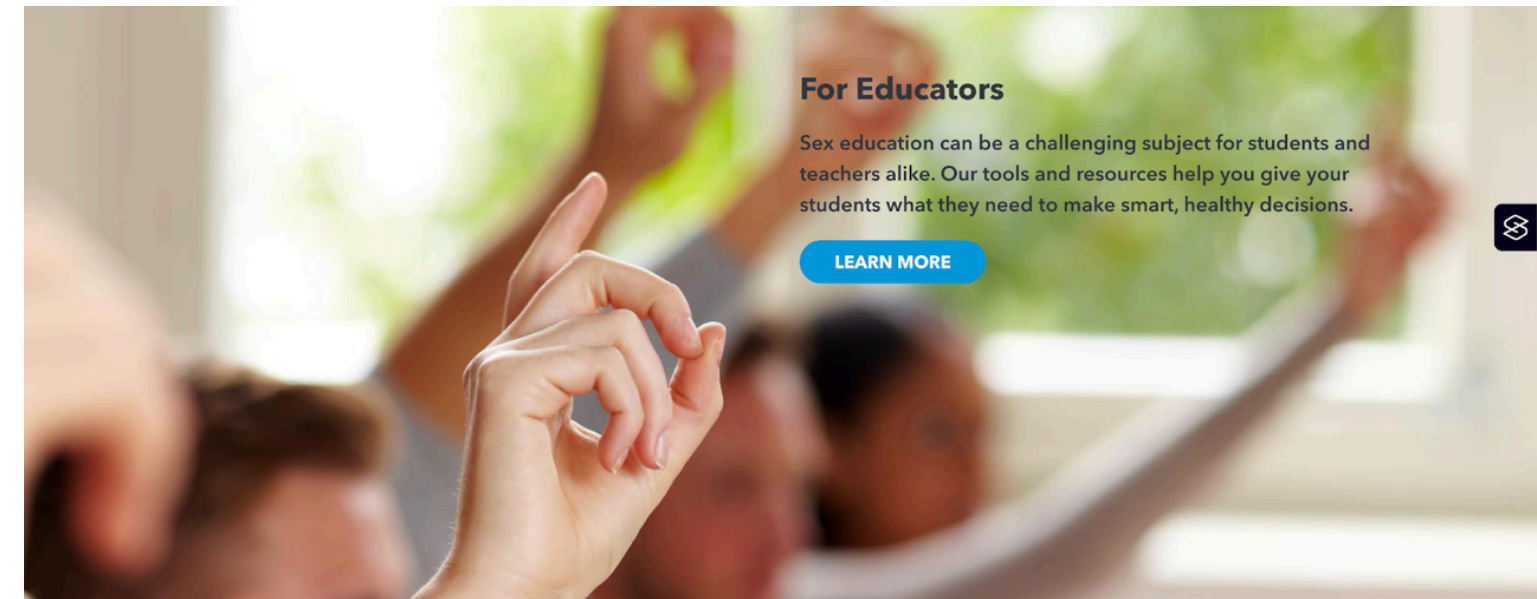
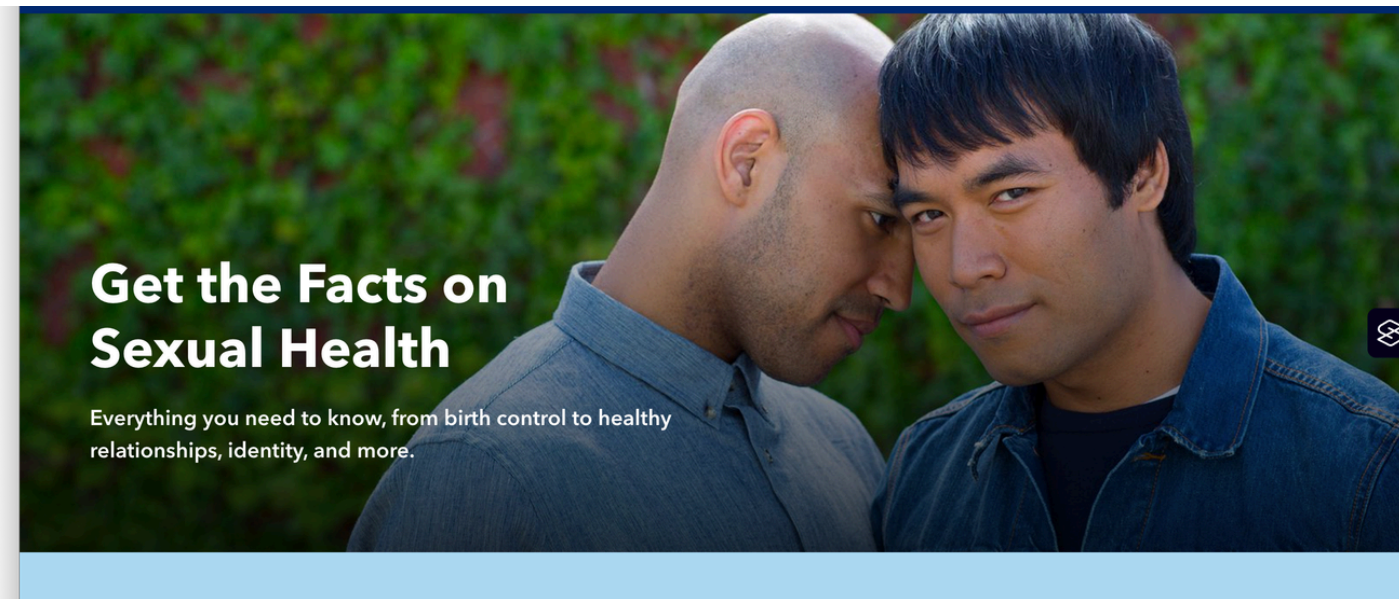
- clear
- accessible
- actionable

Focus

Identify usability gaps that may block access to care or information.

Why Planned Parenthood?

- critical resources for a person's life (sexuality, parenthood, pregnancy)
- Real world impact.



BUSINESS CONTEXT

Org. Overview



Planned Parenthood is a non-profit that provides reproductive, sexual, and mental health resources & education.

Business Goals



Expand healthcare access, judgement-free education on sex/health, advocacy for reproductive rights.

Audience



Women, people who can get pregnant, parents, and LGBTQ+ people in the U.S.

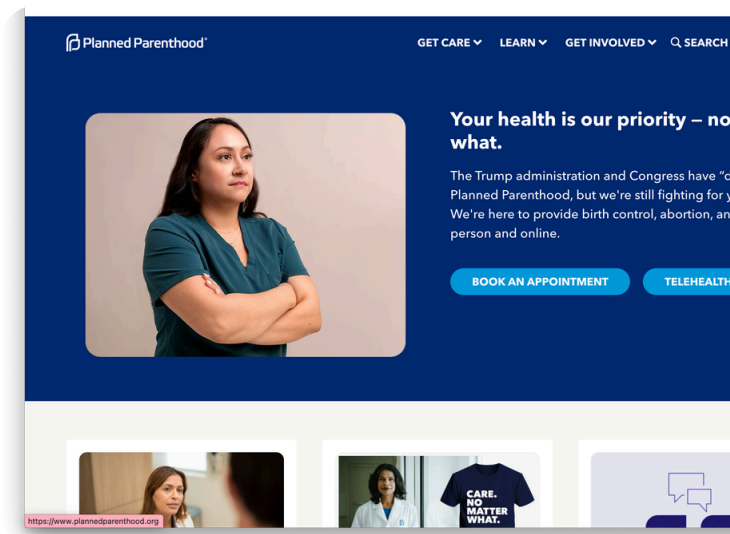
Website Goals



Help users **QUICKLY** find time-sensitive information, guide scheduling, and build organizational trust.

AUDIT SCOPE

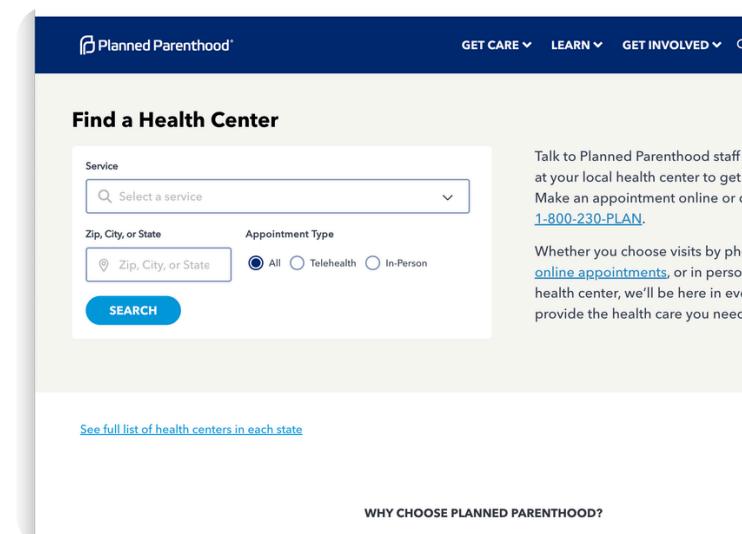
Homepage



Directs users to key actions

- Learning more
- Appointment scheduling

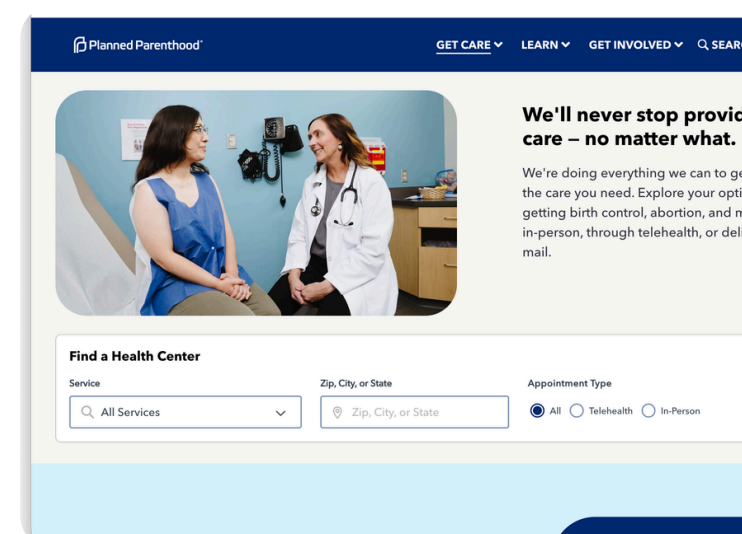
Find a Health Center



Locates

- Health Centers
- Planned Parenthood
- Associated Practices

Get Care



Supports

- Appointment scheduling
- Care options

Learn



Provides

- educational content
 - sexual health, parenting, gender

Why these pages? They represent the ideal path for users.

PART TWO

Website Evaluations,
Methodology, and Findings

EVALUATION 1: PERSONA ANALYSIS

What is it? A fictional description of a target user of the product. Promotes empathy, awareness and memorability of target users, prioritize features, and informs design decisions. Reviewed core pages as Lana.

Persona (abbrv.)



Name: Lana Rey

Age: 22

Occupation: Student at CU

Tech Literacy: High

Personality: Introvert, Efficient,
Tech-savvy

Core Needs:

- Accomplishing digital tasks quickly → busy life and friends.
- Getting things done well the first time
- Easy to navigate interfaces

Findings

The site is viewed as trustworthy and reputable

Key friction points:

- not as efficient as a high-tech-literacy user expects
- auto-filled search fields cause disorientation
- loss of confidence when redirected to third-party scheduling tools

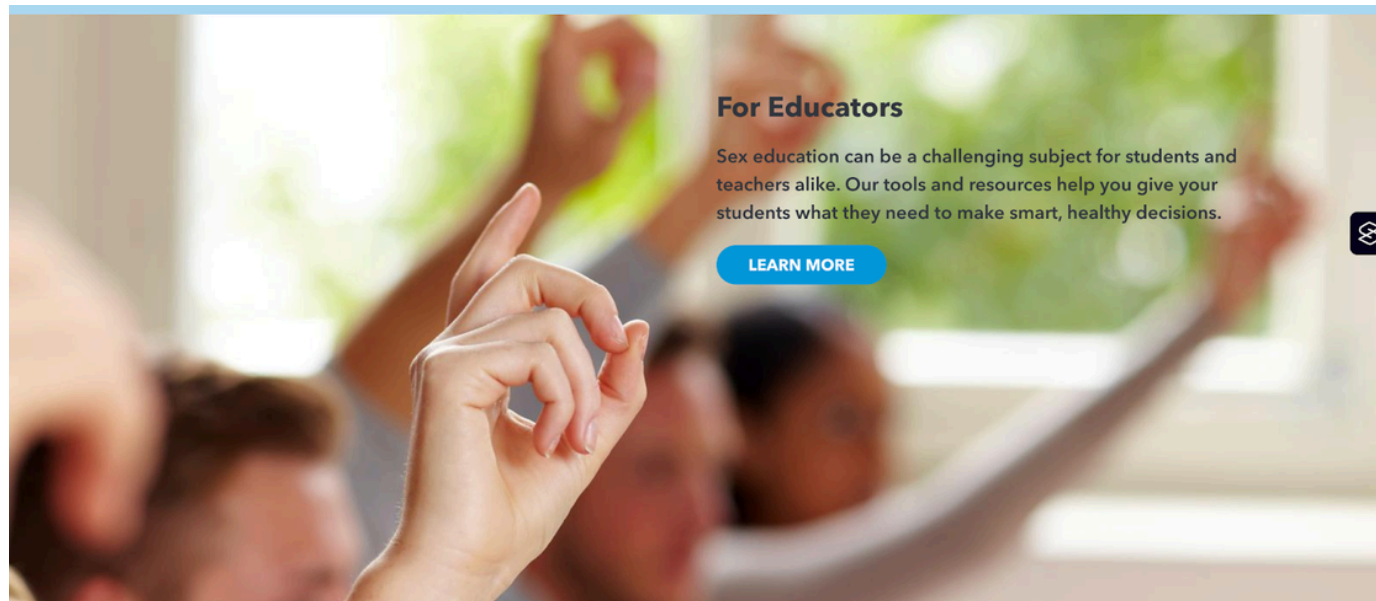
The screenshot shows the 'SELECT A REASON FOR VISIT' section of the Planned Parenthood website. A dropdown menu is open, showing 'Annual Wellness Exam' as the selected option. Below this, a message states: 'Colorado state laws dictates that we must tell the parents of minors about your decision to have an abortion 48 hours before your appointment. A judge may excuse you from this requirement. Because of this, we are unable to schedule this appointment online. Please call us at 303-321-2458 to schedule your appointment.' A button labeled 'Select another provider from below' is visible. The section 'OTHER HEALTH CENTERS MATCHING YOUR VISIT CRITERIA' displays four locations: Planned Parenthood Farmington, Durango, Boulder, and Fort Collins. Each location shows the address, distance, and available appointment times for the selected date. The Farmington location shows times for Wednesday, March 25th (11:00 a, 11:15 a, 11:30 a, and a 'More' link). The Durango location shows times for Tuesday, March 24th (11:30 a, 11:45 a, 12:00 p, and a 'More' link). The Boulder location shows times for Tuesday, March 31st (10:30 a, 12:15 p, 2:30 p, and a 'More' link). The Fort Collins location shows a message: 'Please wait, this is taking longer than expected'.

EVALUATION 2: VISUAL DESIGN

What is it? Assessment of site's colors, typography, and layout for clarity using UX best practices.

Strengths

- **Cohesive look & feel**
- Professional & trustworthy
- Established services with proven value



Example of a 'Hero Image' on the **Learn** page.

Room for Improvement

- **Hero Images** (Pictures that span the entire width of the screen) are too frequent
 - Too much content for easy scrolling
- **Action-based buttons** (CTAs) are often located too low on a page
 - Easy for users to miss

EVALUATION 3: HEURISTICS

What is it? Review of 10 established usability rules created by Jakob Nielsen (Nielsen Norman Group)

Strengths

- **Real-time feedback**
 - Loading indicators
- **Familiar visual patterns**
 - Donations and navigation

Room for Improvement

- **Limited built-in navigation**
 - Users rely on Browser undo/redo buttons
- **Information density**
 - Long pages like "Learn" section

1 Visibility of System Status

Designs should *keep users informed* about what is going on, through appropriate, timely feedback.



Interactive mall maps have to show people where they currently are, to help them understand where to go next.

2 Match between System and the Real World

The design should *speak the users' language*. Use words, phrases, and concepts *familiar to the user*, rather than internal jargon.



Users can quickly understand which stovetop control maps to each heating element.

5 Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs *carefully prevent problems* from occurring in the first place.



Guard rails on curvy mountain roads prevent drivers from falling off cliffs.

8 Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information which is irrelevant. Every extra unit of information in an interface *competes* with the relevant units of information.



A minimalist three-legged stool is still a place to sit.

Nielsen Norman Group Jakob's Ten Usability Heuristics

3 User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a *clearly marked "emergency exit"* to leave the unwanted action.



Just like physical spaces, digital spaces need quick "emergency" exits too.

4 Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. *Follow platform conventions*.



Check-in counters are usually located at the front of hotels, which meets expectations.

6 Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user's memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. Avoid making users remember information.



People are likely to correctly answer "Is Lisbon the capital of Portugal?".

7 Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts — hidden from novice users — may speed up the interaction for the expert user.



Regular routes are listed on maps, but locals with more knowledge of the area can take shortcuts.

9 Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.



Wrong-way signs on the road remind drivers that they are heading in the wrong direction.

10 Help and Documentation

It's best if the design *doesn't need* any additional explanation. However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users complete their tasks.



Information kiosks at airports are easily recognizable and solve customers' problems in context and immediately.

NN/g

www.nngroup.com/articles/ten-usability-heuristics/

EVALUATION 4: ACCESSIBILITY

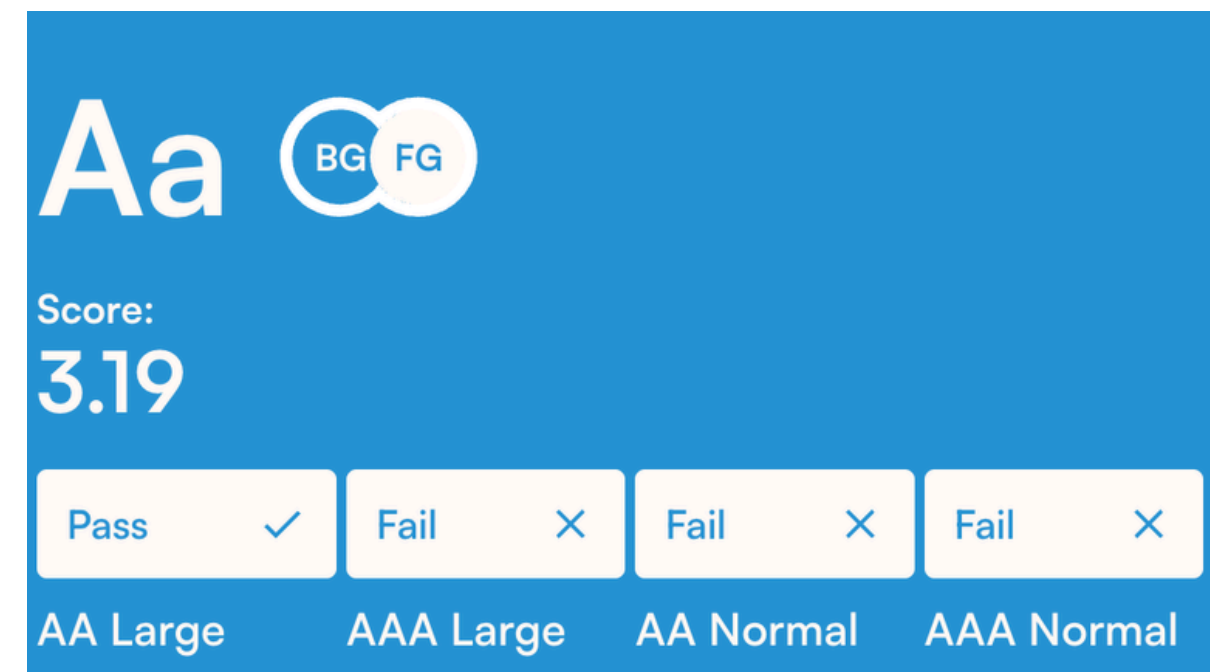
What is it? Audit using WCAG Accessibility best practices and tools like Silktide to determine how disability-friendly a website is.

Strengths

- **Clear vertical visual layout**
 - Supports screenreader navigation
- **Functional keyboard navigation**
 - Supports screenreader navigation

Room for Improvement

- **Missing Alternative Image Descriptions**
 - 'Alt' text describes images to hard-of-vision users.
- **Weak Color Contrast**
 - Difficult for hard-of-vision users



WCAG AA MINIMUM: 4.5:1 for normal text and 3:1 for large text

EVALUATION 5: CONTENT

What is it? An analysis of a site's written copy for brand tone and consistency. Includes smallest details like button labels and error feedback.

Strengths

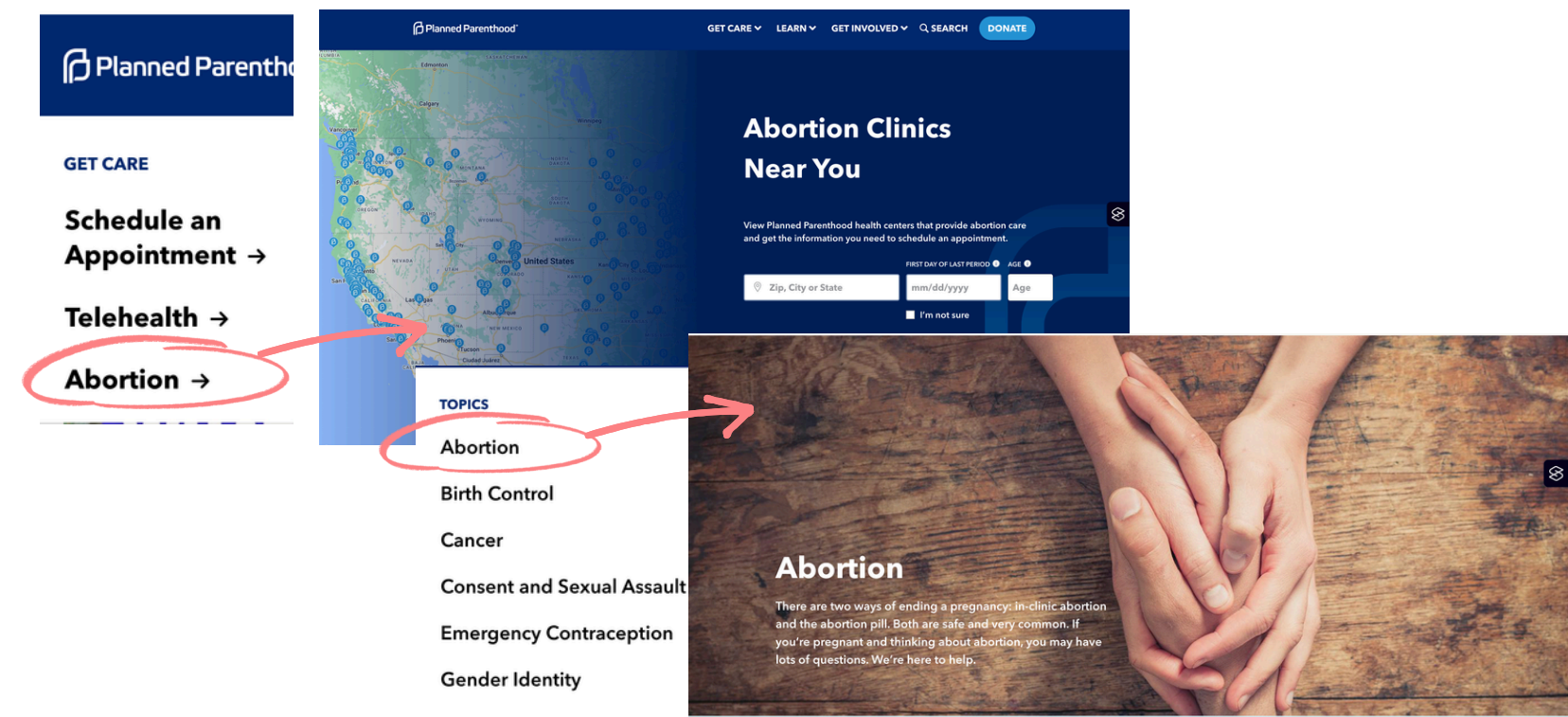
- **Balances professionalism and empathy**
 - calm, judgment-free way
- **Effective use of Tooltips***
 - complex medical jargon

and moral beliefs; family and personal va
t'
Not having sex with anyone. You
can be abstinent if you've had sex
before, are in a relationship, or
have never had sex.
is
st
because you've ha sex before doesn't m
People can be abstinent (not have sex) at

*Example of a 'Tooltip' on the **Learn** page.

Room for Improvement

- **Ambiguous Call to Action (CTA) buttons**
 - Two different buttons labeled "Abortion" leading to different places
- **Appointment scheduler**
 - Lacks a clear step-by-step structure



Abortion button under 'Get Care' and Abortion button under 'Learn' lead to two different pages.

EVALUATION 6: INFORMATION ARCHITECTURE (IA)

What is it? Mapped site structure and page relationships to evaluate organization and navigation. Conducted a card sorting activity to compare existing and potential improved structures.

Card Sorting Process

- Two people received all navigation buttons as digital sticky notes
- Grouped them together as they saw fit

STRENGTHS:

- **Top Level Navigation is intuitive.**

ROOM FOR IMPROVEMENT:

- **'Learn' Subcategory is too broad**
 - Users struggled to group that many cards together



EVALUATION 7: USER JOURNEY

What is it? Mapping out and navigating the ***Golden Path** to identify specific friction points in the site.

Strengths

- **Book An Appointment Visibility**
 - Users are always able to book an appointment on any page
- **Error states**
 - Easy to recover from errors without restarting

Room for Improvement

- **Auto-Filled Forms**
 - Finding appointments can be disorienting due to auto-filled forms
- **Appointment Scheduler**
 - Available appointments are one tedious vertical column.

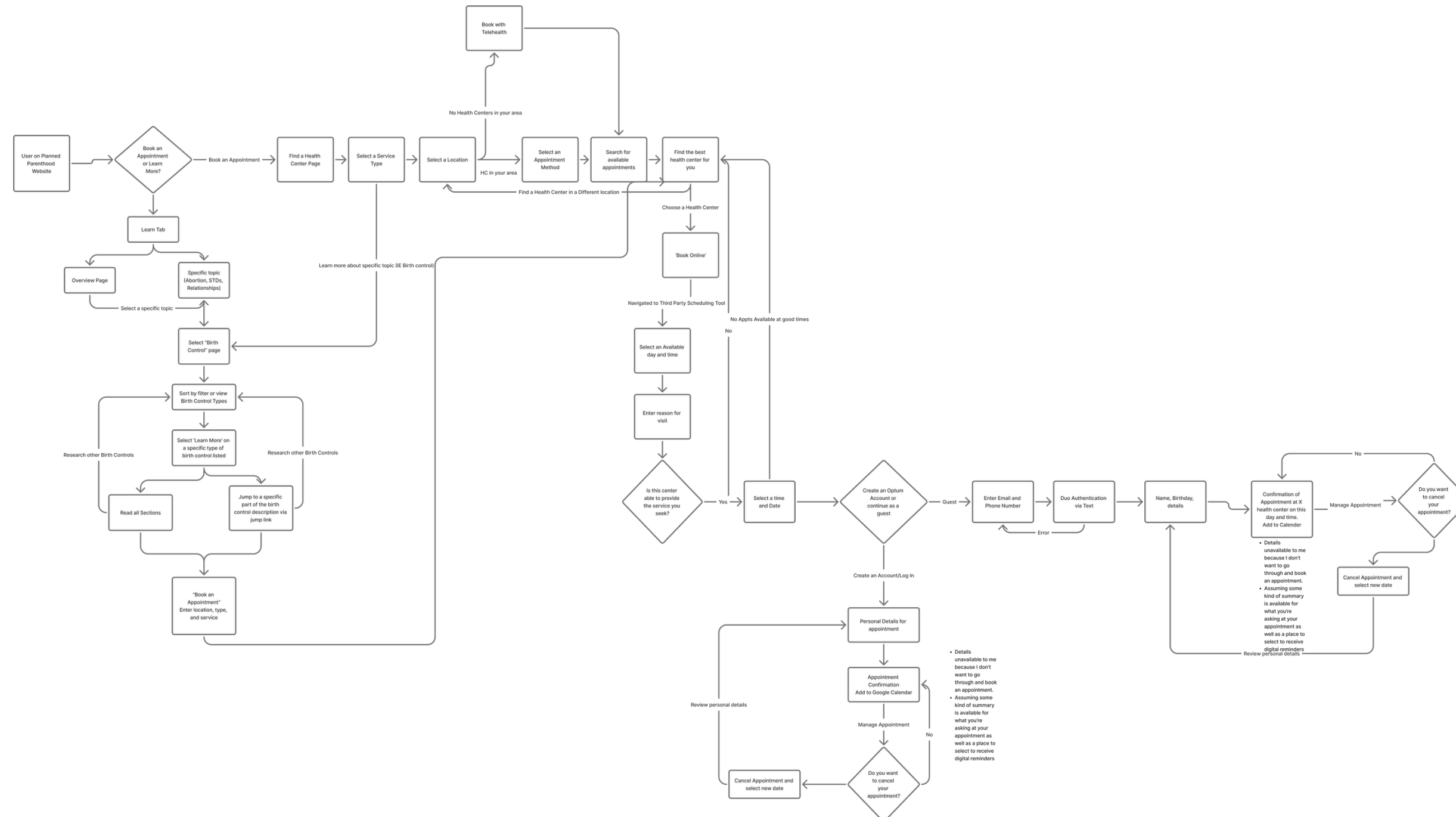
Book an Appointment

Service Zip, City, or State Appointment Type

 ☒ All ☐ Telehealth ☐ In-Person

EVALUATION 7: USER JOURNEY

What is it? Mapping out and navigating the ***Golden Path** to identify specific friction points in the site.



***Golden Path** = Ideal route a user would take to get the most out of a site

PART THREE

Design Recommendations,
Future Ideas

AUDIT THEMES

Areas of the current Planned Parenthood site that are repeated sources of friction for users.

Clarify Appointment Scheduling

Issues recorded in:

- Content Evaluation
- User Journey Evaluation
- Persona Evaluation
- Visual Design Evaluation

Information Density and Comparability

Issues recorded in:

- Content Evaluation
- Persona Evaluation
- Visual Design Evaluation

Simplify Navigation and CTAs

Issues recorded in:

- Content Evaluation
- Information Architecture Evaluation
- Heuristic Evaluation

Improve Accessibility Experience

Issues recorded in:

- Accessibility Evaluation
- Persona Evaluation
- Heuristic Evaluation

STRATEGIC RECOMMENDATIONS

Clarify Appointment Scheduling

- **Restrict which parts of this form are visible**
 - 'Other Health Centers' appear later
 - Redo completely by embedding Optum into Planned Parenthood site and customizing.
- **Provide plenty of tooltips and access to additional information about procedures**
 - Scheduling page specifically

SELECT A REASON FOR VISIT

Annual Wellness Exam

states that we must tell the parents of minors about your decision to have an abortion 48 hours before your appointment. A judge may ex
ment. Because of this, we are unable to schedule this appointment online. Please call us at 303-321-2458 to schedule your appointment

Select another provider from below

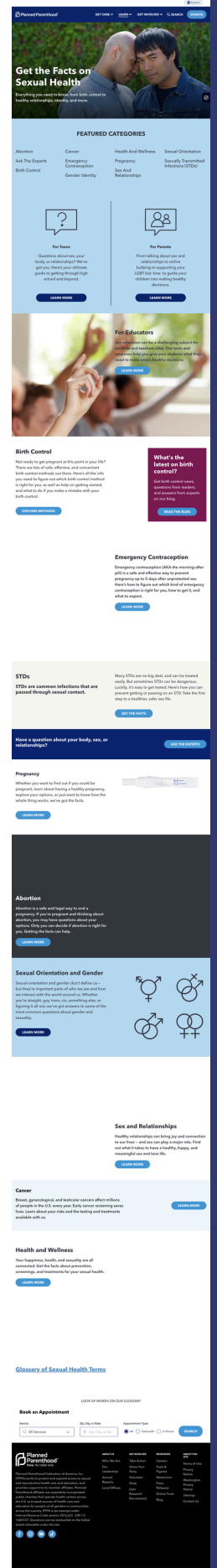
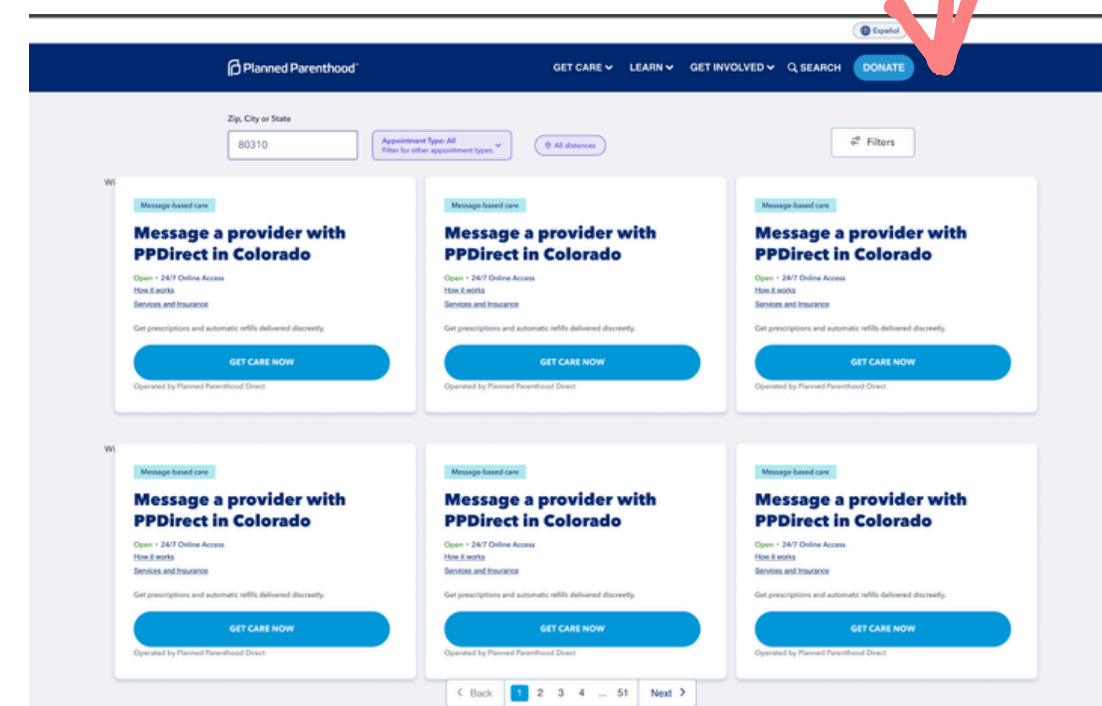
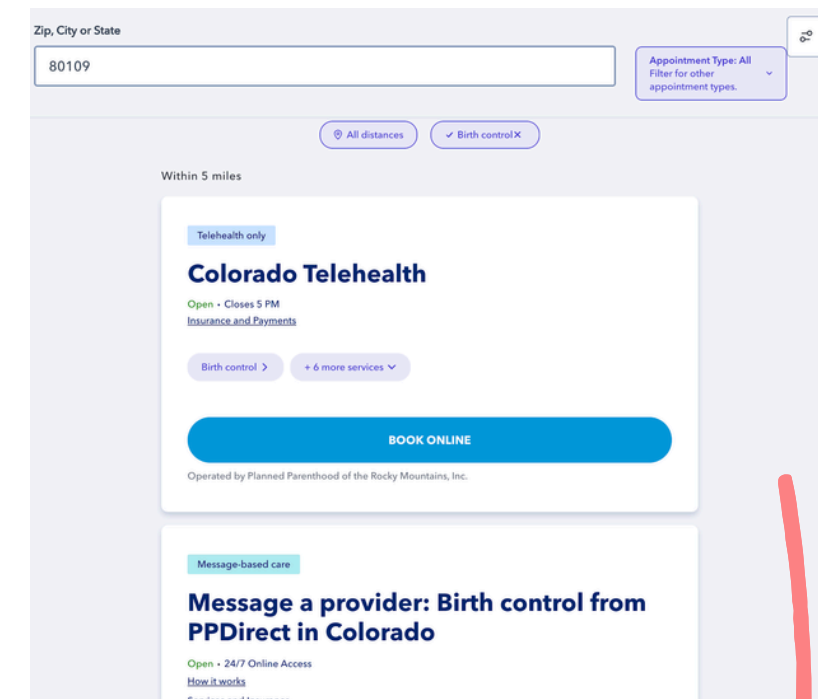
OTHER HEALTH CENTERS MATCHING YOUR VISIT CRITERIA

GTO... IM 87...	 PLANNED PARENTHOOD DURANGO H... 46 Suttle Street, Durango, CO 81303 241.6 mi Tue, Mar 24	 PLANNED PARENTHOOD BOULDER H... 2525 Arapahoe Avenue Suite 200, Boul... 26.4 mi Tue, Mar 31	 PLANNED P... 825 South S... 577 mi Please wait 1
--------------------	--	---	--

STRATEGIC RECOMMENDATIONS

Information Density and Comparability

- **Use the same cards on the site but order them in an HTML grid.**
- **Minimize use of hero images/banners to give white space**

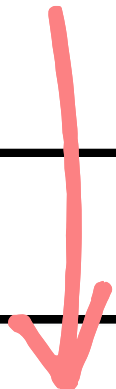


STRATEGIC RECOMMENDATIONS

Simplify Navigation and CTAs

- **Separate information under the Learn navigation into two sections**
 - Topics and Audiences
- **Simplify language**
 - For Parents → Parents
- **Standardize CTA language**
 - Get Care/Abortion → 'See abortion options'
 - Learn/Abortion → 'Abortion'

EXPLORE	TOPICS		RESOURCES AND TOOLS
Overview →	Abortion	Pregnancy	For Teens
Blog →	Birth Control	Relationships	For Parents
	Cancer	Sex, Pleasure, and Sexual Dysfunction	For Educators
	Consent and Sexual Assault		For Health Professionals
	Emergency Contraception	Sexual Orientation	Glossary A - Z
	Gender Identity	Sexually Transmitted Infections (STDs)	Online Tools
	Health and Wellness		



EXPLORE	TOPICS		Audiences
Overview →	Abortion	Pregnancy	Teens
Blog →	Birth Control	Relationships	Parents
Topics →	Cancer	Sex, Pleasure, and Sexual Dysfunction	Educators
Audiences →	Consent and Sexual Assault	Sexual Orientation	Health Professionals
	Emergency Contraception	Sexually Transmitted Infections (STDs)	Glossary A - Z
	Gender Identity		Online Tools
	Health and Wellness		

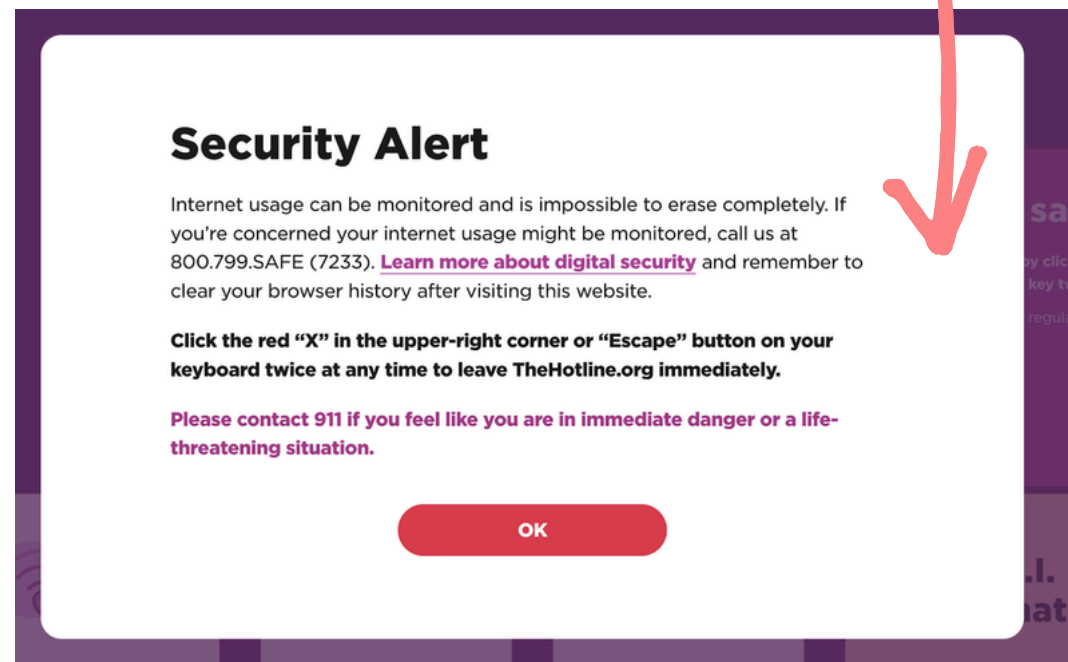
STRATEGIC RECOMMENDATIONS

Accessibility

- **Give all images descriptive alternate text**
 - Ask screenreader users to test them.
- **Fix Color Contrast for WCAG AA**
 - Light Blue / White Specifically
- **Add a quick exit button to easily leave the site in a click**



Alt = "A person in a white lab coat stands next to a navy blue t-shirt with the text "CARE. NO MATTER WHAT." and a Planned Parenthood logo.
Via AltText.ai"



FINAL REFLECTIONS

Efficiency = real-life impact. Keeping things simple and quick will only increase booked appointments.

Accessibility is not optional.

Recommended Next Steps

1. Streamline the appointment scheduling
2. Fix the critical accessibility issues identified

Future Opportunities

Usability tests on the current scheduling flow and compare it to an updated version.

Test alternative layouts for the appointment selection
→ experiment with a dropdown filters

THANK YOU



Averie Dow

averiedow.com

[linkedin.com/in/averiedow/](https://www.linkedin.com/in/averiedow/)